

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1039

By Jones J

A RESOLUTION to honor Tennessee's fifteen African-American-owned Century Farms for their contributions to this State's history, culture, and economy.

WHEREAS, for fifty years, the Tennessee Department of Agriculture has recognized and celebrated families that have owned and cultivated family farmland for 100 or more years through its Century Farm program; in addition to serving as the foundation of Tennessee agriculture, Century Farm families have been foundations for rural communities, contributing land and support for schools, churches, and cemeteries; and

WHEREAS, today, fifteen African-American owned farms are recognized as Tennessee Century Farms; their history relates the resiliency and determination exhibited by African Americans in working their land despite many obstacles, including discriminatory loan practices based on race; and

WHEREAS, post-Civil War, African Americans acquired fifteen million acres of farmland across the South between 1865 and 1919; and

WHEREAS, in 1910, African-American farming peaked in Tennessee, with nearly 11,000 African-American farmers, twenty-eight percent of Tennessee's total, at a time when the State's population was twenty-one percent African American; and

WHEREAS, between 1910 and 1997, African Americans lost approximately ninety percent of their farmland; from the 1920s to today, the percentage of African-American agricultural landowners has steadily dropped from twenty-eight percent to only 1.3% across the nation; and

WHEREAS, this mass exodus was fueled by violent racial animus, lynching, Jim Crowism, and underhanded land dealing and intimidation, coupled with better job prospects in the industrializing North; and

WHEREAS, as a result of this Great Migration, decades-long USDA mismanagement of farm programs, and other factors, Century Farms founded by African-American farmers represent less than one-half of one percent of the total Century Farms recognized by the State of Tennessee today; and

WHEREAS, although their numbers may be small, African-American-owned Century Farms are powerful reminders of the racial discrimination and economic struggles that African-American farmers endured for at least 160 years, as the history of these farms tells an inspirational story of persistence and dedication to overcome many societal obstacles and achieve success in their vocation; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee's fifteen African-American-owned Century Farms include The Moore Family Farm (founded in 1870 in Benton County); The McDonald Craig Farm (founded in 1871 in Perry County); The Drake Farm (founded in 1876 in Sumner County); The Butler Farm (founded in 1880 in Rutherford County); The Ol' Ledford Farm (founded in 1880 in Montgomery County); The Shaw Farm (founded in 1881 in Haywood County); Nelson Bond's Oakview Farm (founded in 1888 in Haywood County); The Robertson Farm (founded in 1888 in Hardeman County); The Gardner Farm (founded in 1889 in Giles County); The Tony Angus Farm (founded in 1891 in Rutherford County); The Hatcher Family Farm (founded in 1903 in Williamson County); The William and Luella Carter Farm (founded in 1903 in Lauderdale County); The Luster Farm (founded in 1906 in Williamson County); The Dix Farm (founded in 1916 in Trousdale County); and The McKinnie Farm (founded in 1918 in Hardeman and Fayette counties); and

WHEREAS, despite the bleak realities of today's agricultural economy, these fifteen African-American families are committed to keeping the rich legacy of African-American farming alive through their Century Farms, and they are most deserving of our approbation; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the families who own and operate Tennessee's fifteen African-American Century Farms for their many contributions to this State's history, culture, and economy and their ongoing commitment to agriculture and their communities, extending to each of them our best wishes for much continued success and happiness.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.